



EDUCATION ABROAD PROGRAM

Marketing, Advising, and Orientation

The pre-departure phase for education abroad begins with the initial communication about education abroad opportunities to students. Each communication piece, event, and activity should be designed to manage student expectations and prepare them for success while abroad. This toolkit is informed by the *Standards of Good Practice for Education Abroad* and is designed to be adapted to your institutional context.

MARKETING

Whether it be print materials, digital images, social media posts, direct emails, or promotional events, marketing materials send explicit and implicit messages to education abroad students, faculty, university administration, and parents about:

- Who education abroad is for
- What education abroad is
- How education abroad should be experienced
- Where education abroad takes place
- Why education abroad is valuable

Take these ideas into account when developing marketing materials or events.

When promoting education abroad programs, it is critical to do so in an ethical and transparent manner. Marketing materials shall not objectify or exploit cultures or people affiliated or unaffiliated with the program or reinforce stereotypes or cultural biases. Permission to use photos taken by or of participants must be secured prior to publication.

ADVISING

The Forum's [Guidelines for Education Abroad Advising](#) detail considerations for effective advising.

Advising will look different at each institution due to academic requirements, resources, and expectations for education abroad participation. Keep these main ideas in mind when developing an advising plan and philosophy.

Some well-known, evidence-based advising strategies include:

1. Asset or Strengths-Based Advising

Avoid reinforcing deficits among students or populations for reasons why individuals do not participate in education abroad (e.g., financial hardship, family pressure, lack of academic preparedness, lack of representation). Prioritize validating the student's ability to be successful, highlight accomplishments, and emphasize skills or knowledge they already possess that will aid in successful education abroad experiences.

See: [Rose, C. \(2022, August 22\). Strengths-Based Advising for Social Justice. Academic Advising Today, 45\(3\).](#)

See also: [Wick, D., Willis, T. Y., Rivera, J., Lueker, E., & Hernandez, M. \(2019\). Assets-Based Learning Abroad: First-Generation Latinx College Students Leveraging and Increasing Community Cultural Wealth in Costa Rica. Frontiers: The Interdisciplinary Journal of Study Abroad, 31\(2\), 63–85. <https://doi.org/10.36366/frontiers.v31i2.455>](#)

2. Appreciative Advising

Appreciative Advising is the intentional collaborative practice of asking generative, open-ended questions that help students optimize their educational experiences and achieve their dreams, goals, and potential (<https://www.appreciativeadvising.net/>).

Sample questions:

- What is your favorite class and why?
- Where do you feel most successful or engaged?
- Where do you feel least successful or engaged?
- Do you have hobbies you enjoy?
- How do you envision your education abroad experience?

See also: <https://nacada.ksu.edu/Resources/NACADA-Companion-Resources/Academic-Advising-Approaches/Appreciative-Advising.aspx>

TOPICS TO COVER:

1. Academic Record

- a. Has the student met institutional requirements for education abroad?
 - i. If not, identify the next steps the student can take to meet institutional requirements.
- b. What programs are they eligible for?
- c. What do they need to do to become or remain eligible for their preferred program?
- d. Which term is ideal for participation?

2. Financial Considerations

- a. Does the preferred program meet their budget expectations?
 - i. If not, what resources or strategies can we share with the student to address financial barriers?
- b. Does the student qualify for internal, program-sponsored, or external scholarships?

3. Travel Documents
 - a. Does the student need a passport?
 - b. Will the student need a visa or special documentation to travel to their preferred program?
 - c. What can the student do now to prepare for applying for necessary travel documents?
4. Goal-Setting: Employ the use of S.M.A.R.T. goal-setting for each category

Specific: "I want to improve my proficiency in Spanish."

Measurable: "I will learn vocabulary related to my academic study."

Attainable: "I will take Spanish for medical professions."

Relevant: "I plan to be a medical professional in a Spanish-speaking environment."

Time-bound: "This is a reasonable goal for the duration of my education abroad program."

 - a. What are the student's academic goals for education abroad?
 - b. How does education abroad fit into the student's career plan?
 - c. What are the student's personal goals for education abroad?

PRE-DEPARTURE ORIENTATION

Pre-departure orientation is an opportunity to reinforce the intended learning outcomes of your education abroad program. Review the education abroad mission, goals, and intended outcomes to reverse-engineer the structure of the orientation and curriculum. Additionally, prioritize important policies and resources to ensure students have the information they need to progress in their academic program as well as manage their own health, safety, and well-being while abroad. Keep in mind that home institution-managed education abroad programs will need to include site-specific information.

TOPICS TO PRIORITIZE:

1. Institutional policies related, but not limited, to:
 - a. Academic expectations
 - b. Course credit transfer and grades
 - c. Student conduct expectations
 - d. Financial model (home school tuition versus program direct fees)
2. Health, safety, and well-being
 - a. Insurance coverage and limitations
 - b. Availability of resources abroad (medical, mental health, accommodations)
 - c. Strategies for managing personal well-being
 - d. Protocols to follow in an emergency
 - e. Security services resources
3. Finances
 - a. Estimated cost of education abroad
 - b. Financial aid availability
 - c. Scholarships
 - d. Budgeting strategies related to goals
 - e. Obtaining local currency

4. Site-specific information
 - a. Course availability
 - b. Typical day on-site
 - c. Housing policies and resources
 - d. Resources for information on local conditions: U.S. State Department, OSAC, interior ministries, local media
 - e. Cultural practices

PREPARING THE WHOLE STUDENT

Cultural competency, lived experience, and goal-setting will be unique to each student and are just as important as providing detailed information on policies, procedures, and health and safety while abroad. Include activities in your orientation that can speak to the development of cultural competency, adaptation to new contexts, and setting and achievement of goals. The Forum on Education Abroad manages peer reviewed examples of resources and programming offered by member institutions as part of our Member Resources. Consider reviewing and adapting an example to meet your institution's goals in promoting these critical skills.

1. Cultural Adaptation
 - a. What is "culture"?
 - b. What are the stages of cultural adaptation?
 - c. What are some strategies for engaging with local communities?
 - d. What may students feel and do upon re-entry?
 - e. Navigating identities in new cultural contexts:
 - i. Which identities are more important to you now?
 - ii. How do you anticipate education abroad to impact these identities?
 - iii. Are there identities that may not be welcome in your host community?
 - iv. How do you anticipate responding to difficult questions of identity while abroad?
2. Academic and Career Integration
 - a. Setting specific goals with academic and career planning in mind
 - b. Outlining skills (both hard and soft) that contribute to a career objective

STRUCTURE OF PRE-DEPARTURE ORIENTATION

Orientation can take many forms, depending on the needs of your students and institutional capacity. In addition to written information (handbook, website, email communication), consider various modalities to deliver content, depending on the desired outcome. Consider what outcomes you want to achieve as a result of a student participating in the pre-departure orientation programming. Depending on the way sessions are designed—whether in person, virtual, or asynchronous, pre-departure orientations can create opportunities for deep engagement and cohort development. Additionally, use of technology can verify a student's level of engagement with the content to ensure critical information was delivered and received.